EDINBURGH, UNITED KINGDOM

# Scottish National Gallery: Masterpieces

Twenty works ranging from an effortless-looking skate to the effort of mourning.



The skater keeps his arms folded while one leg extends behind him. What appears easy is a carefully maintained balance. In Raphael's Madonna, a turning child is held securely; in Hamilton's mourning scene, a dead body must be supported by others. These are different uses of bodily weight, and they offer a thread through a selection that spans sacred subjects, portraits and landscapes.

The still lifes and river views extend the comparison. A black bottle steadies a loose arrangement of objects; poplars and their reflections repeat without becoming identical. Balance is a relation among unequal parts, not simply another name for symmetry or calm.

Artline selected these works from documented museum holdings. The selection is independent of the museum, and individual works may be on loan or off display. Dates and attributions retain the qualifications in the linked records.

## Explore this selection in Artline

See the selected works alongside books and events from their period, or compare when the artists lived. The books and events provide context, not evidence of direct influence. Works without confirmed dates remain in this guide.

Artworks in context  Who lived when?

artlines.org/guides/scottish-national-gallery

# The selection · 20

1. The Skating Minister
   Sir Henry Raeburn · c. 1795
2. The Monarch of the Glen
   Edwin Landseer · 1851
3. Vision after the Sermon
   Paul Gauguin · 1888
4. An Old Woman Cooking Eggs
   Diego Velázquez · 1618
5. Bridgewater Madonna
   Raphael · c. 1507–1508
6. Fable: A Boy Lighting a Candle with an Ape and a Fool
   El Greco · c. 1590
7. Autumn in Glencairn, Moniaive
   James Paterson · 1887
8. Boy with a Horse
   Georges Seurat · 1883
9. Confirmation
   Nicolas Poussin · 1645
10. Mars and Venus
    Paolo Veronese · 1580
11. Mrs Ernest Hill
    John Singer Sargent · c. 1894
12. Oban
    James Guthrie · 1893
13. The Black Bottle
    Samuel Peploe · 1905
14. The Feasts of Venice
    Jean-Antoine Watteau · 1717
15. Virgin and Child with Saints Jerome, Peter, Clare and Francis
    Lorenzo Lotto · 1505
16. Snow Scene at Moret Station
    Alfred Sisley · 1888
17. Christ Blessing
    El Greco · about 1600
18. Poplars on the Epte
    Claude Monet · 1891
19. The Marne at Chennevières
    Camille Pissarro · 1864/65
20. Achilles Lamenting the Death of Patroclus
    Gavin Hamilton · 1760-1763

01 / 20

# The Skating Minister

Sir Henry Raeburn

c. 1795 · Scottish National Gallery



Sir Henry Raeburn. The Skating Minister (The Reverend Robert Walker Skating on Duddingston Loch). Image: WikiArt. Public domain (WikiArt label). Proportionally resized and JPEG compressed; no crop. · Public domain (WikiArt label)

The folded arms make the extended leg and narrow contact with the ice more conspicuous. The museum identifies the sitter cautiously as probably the Reverend Robert Walker and notes that the seemingly easy manoeuvre requires skill. The portrait obtains its character from that discrepancy: composure is visible, while the work of balance is largely concealed.

Object source · Open artwork

02 / 20

# The Monarch of the Glen

Edwin Landseer

1851 · Scottish National Gallery



Edwin Landseer. The Monarch of the Glen. Image: WikiArt. Public domain (WikiArt label). Proportionally resized and JPEG compressed; no crop. · Public domain (WikiArt label)

The stag stands above the surrounding landscape with its antlers outlined against the sky. The low viewpoint gives the animal a commanding position usually associated with a formal human portrait. Its authority is produced by scale and placement; the mountain setting participates in that presentation rather than simply supplying a natural home.

Object source · Open artwork

03 / 20

# Vision after the Sermon

Paul Gauguin

1888 · Scottish National Gallery



Paul Gauguin. The Vision after the Sermon (Jacob wrestling with the Angel). Image: WikiArt. Public domain (WikiArt label). Proportionally resized and JPEG compressed; no crop. · Public domain (WikiArt label)

The white-capped women and distant wrestlers share a red field, but do not occupy it on ordinary naturalistic terms. A diagonal tree divides them, and their scales differ abruptly. Gauguin lets the vision coexist with its witnesses while making the relationship visibly constructed. The colour refuses to behave as neutral ground.

Object source · Open artwork

04 / 20

# An Old Woman Cooking Eggs

Diego Velázquez

1618 · Oil on canvas · Scottish National Gallery



Diego Velázquez. An Old Woman Cooking Eggs. WikiArt source label: Public domain. Proportional resize and JPEG compression; no crop. Source: https://www.wikiart.org/en/diego-velazquez/an-old-woman-cooking-eggs-1618 · Public domain (WikiArt source label)

Faces and utensils receive comparably exact attention in the close kitchen space. The boy's offerings and the woman's work connect glass, food and cooking vessel through practical handling. Velázquez does not leave these materials as incidental accessories. Their different surfaces give the ordinary task much of its substance.

Object source · Open artwork

05 / 20

# Bridgewater Madonna

Raphael

c. 1507–1508 · Scottish National Gallery



Bridgewater Madonna. WikiArt; Raphael. Proportional resizing and JPEG compression; source frame preserved. · Public domain

The child turns across Mary’s lap, introducing a movement her hands must contain. A dark setting makes the two bodies’ relation especially clear. The group remains stable because support answers the twist: the devotional image depends on a recognisable act of holding, not only on the identities of mother and child.

Object source · Open artwork

06 / 20

# Fable: A Boy Lighting a Candle with an Ape and a Fool

El Greco

c. 1590 · Oil on canvas · Scottish National Gallery



El Greco. Allegory, boy lighting candle in the company of an ape and a fool - Fábula. WikiArt source label: Public domain. Proportional resize and JPEG compression; no crop. Source: https://www.wikiart.org/en/el-greco/allegory-boy-lighting-candle-in-the-company-of-an-ape-and-a-fool-f%C3%A1bula · Public domain (WikiArt source label)

The flame gathers an ape, a boy and an older man into one small area of light. Their differences become visible through a common attraction. Before any allegorical interpretation is supplied, the picture establishes a physical relation between illumination and proximity: the heads emerge because they have approached the same source.

Object source · Open artwork

07 / 20

# Autumn in Glencairn, Moniaive

James Paterson

1887 · Scottish National Gallery



James Paterson. Autumn in Glencairn, Moniaive. Image credit: James Paterson; Source credit: https://www.nationalgalleries.org/art-and-artists/5679/autumn-glencairn-moniaive?page=1&search_set_offset=79. Wikimedia Commons. Public domain (https://creativecommons.org/publicdomain/mark/1.0/). Resized and JPEG-compressed; selected source frame preserved. · Public domain

The stream gives a pale route through browns and other closely related tones. Autumn does not require a single emblematic tree; changes accumulate across vegetation, fields and reflections. The water keeps the landscape open enough to follow, while low hills and cloud maintain its subdued scale.

Object source · Open artwork · Inventory: NG 2424

08 / 20

# Boy with a Horse

Georges Seurat

1883 · Oil on wood · Scottish National Gallery



Boy with horse. WikiArt; Georges Seurat. Proportional resizing and JPEG compression; source frame preserved. · Public domain

Abbreviated strokes establish bodies, bank and opposite shore without resolving every surface. Their positions are sufficient to make the riverside occupied. The small work rewards attention to arrangement before finish: a horse, a boy and other figures can define intervals within an open place without becoming separate, fully described portraits.

Object source · Open artwork

09 / 20

# Confirmation

Nicolas Poussin

1645 · Oil on canvas · Scottish National Gallery



Confirmation. WikiArt; Nicolas Poussin. Proportional resizing and JPEG compression; source frame preserved. · Public domain

The sacrament unfolds through a sequence of bodily positions: waiting, approaching and receiving. Bright clothing helps distinguish places within the darker architecture. Poussin makes ceremony intelligible as ordered action, allowing the group to share a space without requiring every participant to occupy the same moment of the rite.

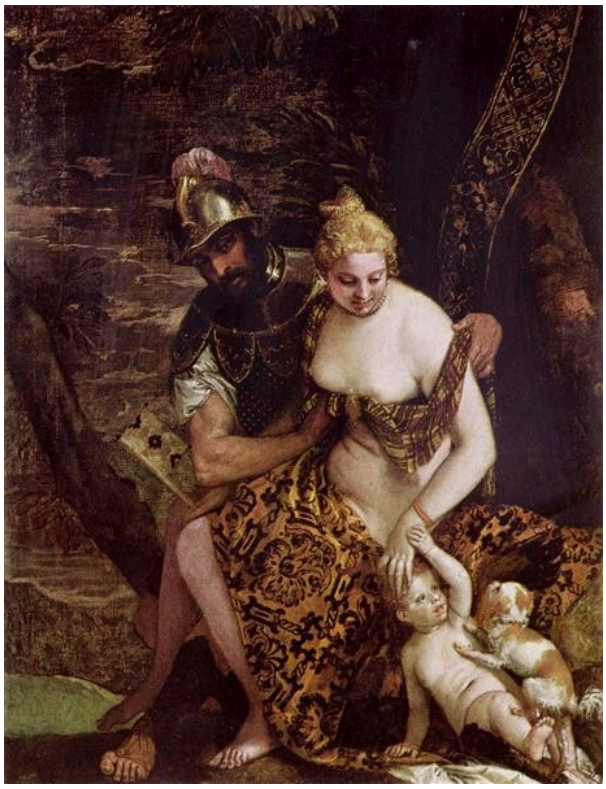
Object source · Open artwork

10 / 20

# Mars and Venus

Paolo Veronese

1580 · Oil on canvas · Scottish National Gallery



Mars and Venus. WikiArt; Paolo Veronese. Proportional resizing and JPEG compression; source frame preserved. · Public domain

Armour and soft clothing give the close encounter contrasting surfaces. Mars and Venus are connected by posture and touch, with Cupid adding another relation below. The mythological names identify the participants, but the material contrast does additional work: hardness and yielding fabric remain in immediate contact.

Object source · Open artwork

11 / 20

# Mrs Ernest Hill

John Singer Sargent

c. 1894 · Oil on canvas · Scottish National Gallery



John Singer Sargent. Mrs. Ernest Hill (Constance Malanie Wynne Roberts). WikiArt source label: Public domain. Proportional resize and JPEG compression; no crop. Source: https://www.wikiart.org/en/john-singer-sargent/mrs-ernest-hill-constance-malanie-wynne-roberts · Public domain (WikiArt source label)

Dark dress and surrounding shadow occupy broad areas, making the pale trim and resting hand unusually important. Those limited accents describe both the sitter’s clothing and the adjustment of her pose. Sargent does not need equal illumination everywhere; the portrait’s presence depends on where distinctions become clear.

Object source · Open artwork

12 / 20

# Oban

James Guthrie

1893 · Scottish National Gallery



James Guthrie. Oban. Image credit: James Guthrie; Source credit: https://www.nationalgalleries.org/art-and-artists/4999/oban?page=1&search_set_offset=90. Wikimedia Commons. Public domain (https://creativecommons.org/publicdomain/mark/1.0/). Resized and JPEG-compressed; selected source frame preserved. · Public domain

The curve of the waterfront organises a town built from broad, related greys. A pale promenade leads through the scene, while boats give the subdued water points of scale. Guthrie keeps the topography legible without individually detailing every building. The route along the shore holds the larger masses together.

Object source · Open artwork · Inventory: NG 2087

13 / 20

# The Black Bottle

Samuel Peploe

1905 · Oil on canvas · Scottish National Gallery



Samuel Peploe. The Black Bottle. WikiArt source label: Public domain. Proportional resize and JPEG compression; no crop. Source: https://www.wikiart.org/en/samuel-peploe/the-black-bottle-1905 · Public domain (WikiArt source label)

The bottle supplies one firm dark vertical among rounded objects and folded white cloth. It steadies the arrangement while making differences within the whites easier to notice. The small still life has no need of a narrative event: contrasts of weight, height and light provide enough relations to sustain looking.

Object source · Open artwork

14 / 20

# The Feasts of Venice

Jean-Antoine Watteau

1717 · Oil on canvas · Scottish National Gallery



The Feasts of Venice. WikiArt; Jean-Antoine Watteau. Proportional resizing and JPEG compression; source frame preserved. · Public domain

The dance does not absorb every figure’s attention in the same way. Companions, performers and onlookers occupy different positions around the garden and fountain. A pale dress supplies a strong accent without making the whole gathering uniform. Festivity appears as several kinds of participation, not one emotion assigned to an entire crowd.

Object source · Open artwork

15 / 20

# Virgin and Child with Saints Jerome, Peter, Clare and Francis

Lorenzo Lotto

1505 · Oil on canvas · Scottish National Gallery



Lorenzo Lotto. Virgin and Child with Saints Jerome, Peter, Clare and Francis. WikiArt source label: Public domain. Proportional resize and JPEG compression; no crop. Source: https://www.wikiart.org/en/lorenzo-lotto/virgin-and-child-with-saints-jerome-peter-clare-and-francis-1505 · Public domain (WikiArt source label)

The reaching child and nearby saints form a close exchange of hands and faces. A narrow landscape remains above them, but little space separates the principal bodies. Saints from different histories share a devotional arrangement here; their proximity should be read as the image’s construction rather than evidence of a single historical meeting.

Object source · Open artwork

16 / 20

# Snow Scene at Moret Station

Alfred Sisley

1888 · Pastel · Scottish National Gallery



Alfred Sisley. Snow Scene Moret Station. WikiArt source label: Public domain. Proportional resize and JPEG compression; no crop. Source: https://www.wikiart.org/en/alfred-sisley/snow-scene-moret-station-1888 · Public domain (WikiArt source label)

Dark branches and narrow fences interrupt the snow’s broad light surface. Softer pastel marks keep buildings and winter air closely related, avoiding the effect of objects cut sharply out of a uniformly white ground. Sisley differentiates the place through limited contrasts, letting reduced visibility become part of its character.

Object source · Open artwork

17 / 20

# Christ Blessing

El Greco

about 1600 · Scottish National Gallery



El Greco. Christ Blessing (The Saviour of the World). Image credit: El Greco; Source credit: 2. Scottish National Gallery 1. Google Arts & Culture. Public domain (https://creativecommons.org/publicdomain/mark/1.0/). Proportional resize and JPEG compression; full source frame retained. · Public domain

The raised hand establishes a blessing as clearly as the face establishes a direct address. Red and blue drapery give the elongated figure a restrained setting, while the globe belongs to its sacred role. The picture’s relation to the spectator differs from an ordinary likeness: the gesture actively accompanies the gaze.

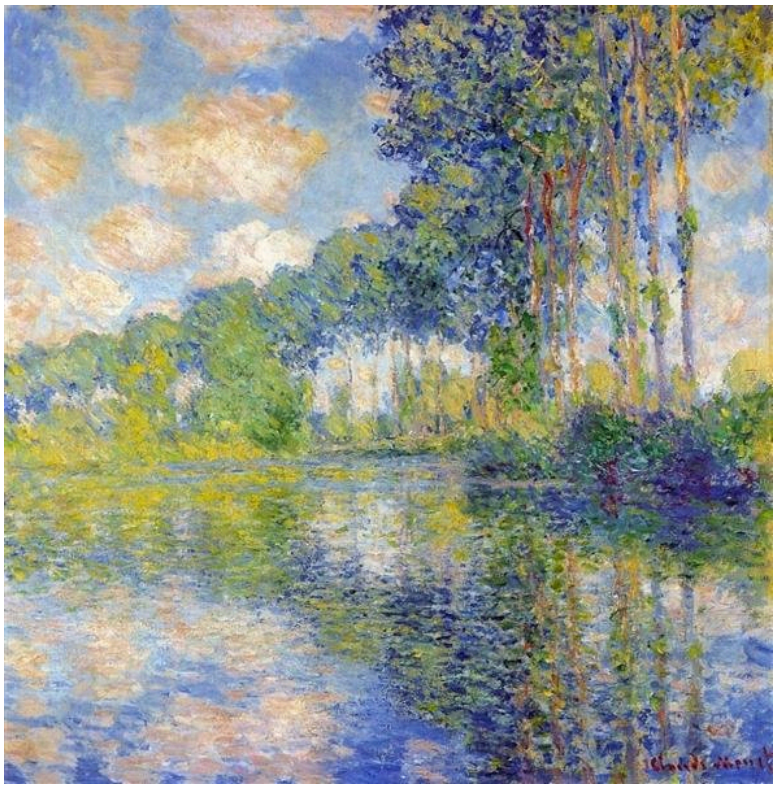
Object source · Open artwork · Inventory: NG 2160

18 / 20

# Poplars on the Epte

Claude Monet

1891 · Scottish National Gallery



Claude Monet. Poplars on the Epte. Image: WikiArt. Public domain (WikiArt label). Proportionally resized and JPEG compressed; no crop. · Public domain (WikiArt label)

The trunks repeat above the bank and continue below it in reflections that are less stable. Similar verticals receive different colours and surrounding marks, so repetition never becomes exact duplication. Monet uses the row to make variation legible; the water supplies a second, shifting account of the same structure.

Object source · Open artwork · Inventory: NG 1651

19 / 20

# The Marne at Chennevières

Camille Pissarro

1864/65 · Scottish National Gallery




Camille Pissarro. The Marne at Chennevières. Image: WikiArt. Public domain (WikiArt label). Proportionally resized and JPEG compressed; no crop. · Public domain (WikiArt label)

The river lies between a wooded bank and distant settlement, with boats and buildings offering small measures of human occupation. Broad divisions of water, land and sky keep those details from fragmenting the view. The landscape remains open, but its openness belongs to a place used and inhabited.

Object source · Open artwork · Inventory: NG 2098

20 / 20

# Achilles Lamenting the Death of Patroclus

Gavin Hamilton

1760-1763 · Scottish National Gallery



Gavin Hamilton. Achilles Lamenting the Death of Patroclus. Image: WikiArt. Public domain (WikiArt label). Proportionally resized and JPEG compressed; no crop. · Public domain (WikiArt label)

The dead body provides a diagonal toward which the surrounding gestures are directed. Achilles bends close, while companions supply support the body can no longer give itself. Hamilton gives mourning the scale of a public history painting, but the principal relation remains physical: grief gathers around weight that others must carry.

Object source · Open artwork

# Choose comparisons before choosing a route

The skater, Raphael’s child and Hamilton’s dead warrior offer three distinct conditions of bodily support. They need not be seen as one chronological argument. Check individual venue and display information: Scotland’s national collection is presented across different buildings, and a work associated with this guide may currently be shown elsewhere in that network.

# Further reading

## Seven Discourses on Art

Joshua Reynolds · Read free · English

Reynolds’s Discourses record an eighteenth-century argument about the ambitions and methods of painting. Read them alongside Raeburn and Hamilton, while keeping their prescriptive account distinct from the very different later pictures here.

---

Museum website · Official collection guide

Sources and visitor information checked: 2026-10-12

---